Food Dehydrator



Category: **Food Processing & Kitchen** Type: **Full SOP** Priority: **High** 2 labs

Covers these lab items: Dehydrator

What it is used for

A food dehydrator removes moisture from food using controlled airflow and heat to support drying and storage. Follow the equipment instructions and validated food-safety process for the specific product.

Main parts

- Drying chamber and trays
- Heating element
- Fan and airflow vents
- Temperature and timer controls
- Door or lid and seals
- Power cord and removable drip tray, if fitted

Before you start

1. Place the dehydrator on a stable, level surface with sufficient ventilation.
2. Inspect the cord, plug, door, trays, fan vents, and chamber.
3. Clean and sanitise food-contact surfaces using approved methods.
4. Select fresh, suitable food and wash it using safe food-handling practices.
5. Cut food into uniform pieces and pretreat only as required by the recipe.
6. Check the recommended temperature, loading arrangement, and drying time for the food.

How to use

1. Ensure the unit is switched off before loading trays.
2. Arrange food in a single layer with gaps for airflow.
3. Do not overload trays or block the fan and air vents.
4. Insert trays evenly and close the door or lid securely.
5. Connect the plug to a suitable electrical outlet.
6. Set the temperature and timer according to the approved process.
7. Start the dehydrator and confirm that airflow and heating operate normally.
8. Check progress at suitable intervals using clean utensils and safe handling practices.
9. Rotate trays only if recommended by the manufacturer or process instructions.
10. Verify dryness using the appropriate product-specific check; do not rely only on appearance.
11. Switch off and unplug the unit when drying is complete.
12. Allow hot trays to cool safely before handling.
13. Cool the dried food as required and pack it in clean, suitable containers.

4. Clean the chamber, trays, and removable parts after use.

⚠ Safety

- Keep the unit away from water and wet work surfaces.
- Use heat-resistant protection when handling hot trays and food.
- Do not block ventilation openings or operate the unit with damaged wiring.
- Use safe food-handling practices to prevent cross-contamination.
- Follow validated temperature and drying guidance; drying alone may not destroy all pathogens.
- Unplug the unit and allow it to cool before cleaning or maintenance.

Care & storage

- Wash and dry removable trays and accessories after use.
- Clean the chamber with an approved method; do not immerse electrical parts.
- Keep fan vents clear of dust and food particles.
- Inspect seals, wiring, controls, and fan operation regularly.

Common mistakes to avoid

- Overloading trays and restricting airflow.
- Using unsuitable temperature or drying time for the food.
- Packing food before it has cooled as required by the process.
- Assuming food is safe for long-term storage based on appearance alone.

Disclaimer: This SOP is prepared from general information available on the internet. For detailed instructions, refer to the manufacturer's original manual / file.